



on the forehand wing, where he belted 17 winners. But newly married Paul had something else to celebrate, albeit briefly, in the third game. When Alcaraz's super-angle forehand pushed him way outside the alley, Paul fashioned the shot of the tournament, a 100-mph forehand around the net post that landed just inside the sideline and baseline.

Alcaraz's quarter was filled with upset-minded contenders determined to dethrone him, none more dangerous than Shelton or more surprising than unseeded Stefanos Tsitsipas. Nicknamed 'The Greek Freak' during his halcyon days, when he made two Major finals and ranked No. 3, Tsitsipas has fallen on hard times. Taught technique by his Russian mother and coached by his Greek father, he was often hampered by their discordant arguments and conflicting advice from the player box. In addition, his antiquated one-handed backhand became increasingly exploited by booming kick serves and heavy topspin groundstrokes.

Nine years ago, Tsitsipas burst on

to the scene by upsetting the legendary Federer, another exponent of the one-handed backhand, to make the Australian Open quarterfinals. Now 28 and ranked a lowly No. 88, he suddenly rediscovered that form to stun No. 10 Arthur Fils 4-6, 7-6(3), 6-1, 6-4 in the first round. A big server and a decisive volleyer, the 6ft 4in Tsitsipas proved that upset was no fluke by taking down No. 18 Jiri Lehecka 2-6, 6-1, 7-6(3), 6-1.

Shelton, who captured four titles on three different court surfaces this season, squelched Tsitsipas' impressive but brief resurgence 6-2, 6-3, 6-4. Big Ben's extreme serve-speed variance, from 147 to 86 mph, and a diabolical array of lefty slice and kick serves, with an average bounce apex of 6ft 1in, exposed the great weaknesses of the one-handed backhand. For the first time in 149 years, since the first Wimbledon Championships in 1877, no man with a one-handed backhand reached the semifinals at any Grand Slam event in a season. In

**Local hero:** Ben Shelton came into the final in red hot form, having beaten Carlos Alcaraz and Frances Tiafoe in consecutive games. AFP

several years this century, that has already happened in women's professional tennis.

Although Shelton ranks No. 2 in serve-games-held percentage (89.9) on the ATP Tour, he ranks an abysmal No. 80 in percentage of return games won (14.4). That is why he practises his return of serve for 90 minutes every day.

That hard work paid off. Shelton was 0-3 against Alcaraz and had broken serve only twice in all those matches. In his 6-7(5), 6-1, 6-3, 1-6, 7-6(10-7) quarterfinal upset, 'Big Ben' broke the Spanish dynamo's serve five times to become the first lefty and first American to defeat Alcaraz at a Major and end his 18-match winning streak at Majors.

The eagerly anticipated

